



CRESTED GECKO · CORRELOPHUS CILIATUS

Keep your crested gecko the right way from day one.

A complete, checked-fact printable manual: vertical enclosure setup, the humidity cycle this species actually needs, CGD-based feeding, and the delicate handling routines that keep a crested gecko thriving for its full multi-decade lifespan.

21 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 5 through 9 in order before buying anything. Housing, temperature/humidity, and diet decisions are expensive and stressful to redo, and this species can be sensitive to major layout changes once settled in. Get the enclosure height and humidity cycle right the first time, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 15 to buy once.

If your gecko is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Temperature/Humidity Targets on page 13 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 10 if anything seems off.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 13: Setup Checklist & Temperature/Humidity Targets | ☐ Page 18: Daily, Weekly, Monthly & Seasonal Routine |
| ☐ Page 14: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 19: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 17: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 20: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Crested gecko husbandry differs sharply from more commonly kept reptiles: little to no supplemental heat, a genuine humidity cycle rather than constant dampness, and delicate handling where a single wrong grab can cost a tail permanently. This package reflects current temperature, humidity, and handling standards, cross-checked against veterinary and herpetological sources, not recycled forum advice.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Correlophus ciliatus</i>
Adult size	7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm)
Captive lifespan	15 to 20+ years typical, some individuals living into their 30s
Native range	New Caledonia, South Pacific
Diet type	Omnivore; commercial crested gecko diet (CGD) as the staple, insects as an occasional supplement
Enclosure style	Vertical and arboreal; more height than floor space, dense climbing structure
Heating needs	Minimal; most homes need no supplemental heat at all
Handling difficulty	Beginner, but delicate; tail loss (autotomy) is permanent

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$300 to \$600 typical, covering the gecko, enclosure, heating if your home needs it, thermostat, substrate, and furnishings.

Ongoing costs

CGD powder, occasional feeder insects, and misting/humidity supplies. Modest compared to setup, since heating needs are minimal for most homes.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

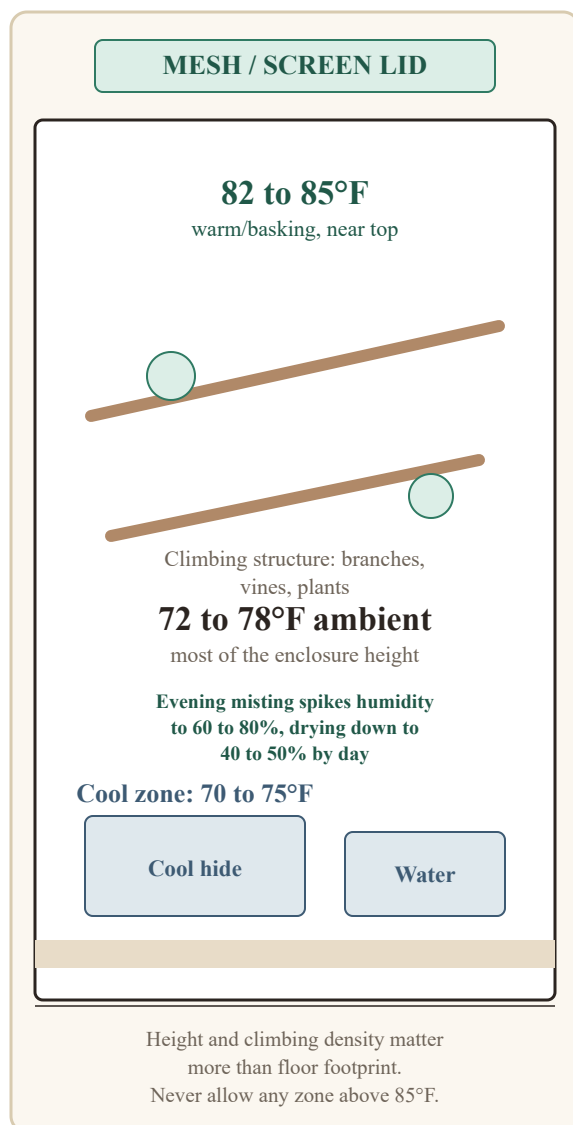
Emergency care isn't rare enough to ignore. Impaction and severe stuck shed can both require a vet visit and, occasionally, a minor procedure. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but both are real enough to plan for.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Crested geckos were considered extinct for decades until they were rediscovered on New Caledonia in 1994.
- They have no eyelids and lick their own eyes clean instead of blinking.
- Sticky toe pads plus claws let them climb almost any surface, including glass.

Housing & enclosure

Crested geckos are arboreal and live in the vertical space, not on the floor. A tall enclosure with dense climbing structure matters more than floor footprint. This species can be sensitive to layout changes once settled in.



NEVER

Let temperatures anywhere in the enclosure exceed 85°F. Crested geckos overheat easily, and heat stress can turn dangerous fast. Most homes kept at normal room temperature need no supplemental heat at all.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Rearrange only occasionally, not with full overhauls, once your gecko is settled in.
- A humidity spike from evening misting, then a genuine daytime dry-down, matters as much as any single temperature number (page 6).

Temperature, humidity & lighting

ZONE	TARGET
Cool area	70 to 75°F
Ambient	72 to 78°F
Basking area	82 to 85°F
Maximum, anywhere in the enclosure	85°F, never exceed
Humidity, evening peak (after misting)	60 to 80%
Humidity, daytime low	40 to 50%

Measure at gecko height with a digital thermometer and hygrometer, not by feel. Most homes need no added heat at all; add a low-wattage heat source only if your home runs cooler than the cool-area target.

Humidity needs a real cycle, not constant dampness

Mist in the evening to spike humidity toward 60 to 80%, then let it dry down to 40 to 50% by day. The dry period matters as much as the misting: an enclosure kept soggy around the clock invites skin and scale problems and doesn't match how this species actually lives (page 11).

UVB (optional)

Not strictly required, since a complete crested gecko diet (CGD) already supplies vitamin D3. Low-level, low-UVI UVB is commonly recommended as a health benefit if used; this species doesn't need the strong output a basking reptile requires.

Photoperiod

Roughly a 12 hour photoperiod: lights or UVB on for about half the day and off the other half, on a consistent schedule.

NICE TO HAVE

A lighting timer and a misting reminder keep the photoperiod and humidity cycle consistent even on busy days.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Repeated stuck shed, especially toes and eyes	Humidity too low, or no real evening spike
Condensation constantly coating the glass	Enclosure too wet, no daytime dry-down
Gecko avoids the upper enclosure, sticks to coolest surfaces	Ambient or basking area running too warm

Diet & feeding

A commercial crested gecko diet (CGD) powder mixed with water is the staple, complete diet for this species, not a supplement to something else. Occasional, appropriately sized insects can be offered as enrichment and a supplement, not as the base diet.

CGD basics

- ☐ Mix CGD powder with water to the consistency the packaging recommends
- ☐ Offer fresh, and replace it on the schedule the product recommends since it can spoil
- ☐ Place the dish within the climbing structure, not only on the floor
- ☐ Vary the dish location occasionally to encourage natural foraging

Insects, as enrichment, not the base diet

Offer appropriately sized insects occasionally alongside CGD. Size prey to your gecko, not the other way around: anything noticeably wider than the space between its eyes is a poor choice.

NEVER FEED

Insects sized wider than your gecko's head. This is a real impaction risk, covered in more detail on page 12.

Hydration

CGD supplies meaningful hydration on its own, and evening misting gives your gecko water droplets to drink directly off leaves and enclosure surfaces, which many crested geckos prefer over a still water dish. Offer a shallow water dish anyway as a backup source.

Handling

Handling a crested gecko is delicate, and one wrong grab can cost a tail permanently. Patience here isn't optional.

Wait until your gecko is ready

Hold off on regular handling until your gecko reaches at least 8 to 15 grams (around 10 g minimum), about 4 to 5 inches long, and roughly 6 months old. Give a newly arrived gecko about 2 weeks to acclimate before any handling beyond feeding and cleaning.

Session length

- ☐ Start sessions at 1 to 2 minutes
- ☐ Build up gradually toward around 15 minutes
- ☐ 20 minute per day cap, across all sessions combined
- ☐ Support the full body, never grip or restrain

NEVER

Grab or restrain by the tail. Tail loss (autotomy) is a real defense mechanism, and it is permanent, the tail will not regrow the way it did before. Let your gecko move across your hands rather than gripping it.

Reading your gecko

A gecko that jumps away, vocalizes (a soft chirp or bark), or repeatedly tries to bolt is telling you the session is over. End calmly rather than pushing through it; repeated stressful handling early on makes every future session harder, not easier.

BUILDING TRUST

Short, low-pressure sessions started only after full acclimation build tolerance far faster than one long session too soon. Let your gecko climb onto your hand voluntarily when possible.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Adding supplemental heat "just in case" and pushing any zone above 85°F, which is genuinely dangerous for this species.
- Misting once and calling it done, with no real daytime dry-down, keeping the enclosure soggy around the clock.
- Grabbing or restraining by the tail, causing permanent, avoidable tail loss.
- Handling before a gecko has acclimated or reached a safe minimum size, weight, and age.
- Rearranging the whole enclosure at once "to freshen it up," which this species can find genuinely stressful.
- Skipping vertical climbing space in favor of floor space, this is an arboreal species, not a ground dweller.
- Using loose or oversized-particle substrate, which adds an impaction risk on top of oversized insects.

Enrichment, by priority

Climbing structure

Branches, vines, and cork bark at varied heights let your gecko use the vertical space it's built for; this also matters directly for preventing floppy tail syndrome (page 12).

Live or realistic plants

Pothos, philodendron, sansevieria, and bromeliads all work well, providing cover, climbing surfaces, and places to rest during the day.

Occasional rearrangement

Reposition or refresh one item occasionally rather than overhauling the whole layout; total resets can be genuinely stressful for this species.

Feeding location variety

Placing the CGD dish at different heights within the climbing structure encourages natural foraging movement.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Sunken eyes, repeated stuck sheds, a visibly limp or drooping tail, straining without producing waste, a visible lump along the belly, lethargy paired with any warm reading in the enclosure, or noticeable weight loss between log entries.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Current cool/ambient/basking readings and recent humidity pattern
- ☐ Weight and shed history from the Owner Log
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Diet over the last two weeks: CGD plus any insects offered

Why temperature and humidity come up first

Most of the issues in this section, stuck shed, metabolic bone disease, and floppy tail syndrome, trace back to a temperature, humidity, or enclosure setup problem more often than anything else. A vet will ask about your setup before anything else for exactly that reason.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
A single missed meal, especially right after a shed	Refusing food for an extended stretch with no clear cause
Brief lethargy right after a big meal or during a shed cycle	Persistent lethargy with no clear trigger, especially with a warm reading nearby
A shed that completes within a day or two with minimal help	Repeated stuck shed on the same toes or eyes, cycle after cycle

Stuck shed & metabolic bone disease

Stuck Shed (Dysecdysis)

Cause: humidity running too low, or no real evening spike to trigger a full shed, especially around the toes and eyes. **Signs:** retained skin on toes or around the eyes days after the rest of the body has shed. **Response:** raise evening humidity and misting frequency, and gently assist only where skin is already loosening, never force or peel unshed skin. **Recovery:** most stuck shed resolves within a cycle or two once the humidity cycle is corrected; retained shed left unaddressed on toes can restrict circulation over time.

PREVENTION BEATS TREATMENT

A consistent evening misting routine that actually spikes humidity into the 60 to 80% range (page 6) prevents most stuck shed before it starts.

Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD)

Cause: inadequate calcium or vitamin D3 relative to need, over time; less common in crested geckos than in some other reptiles since a complete CGD already supplies D3, but still possible. **Signs:** soft or swollen jaw, difficulty climbing or gripping, tremors. **Diagnosis:** veterinary physical exam, often with an X-ray to check bone density. **Response:** vet diagnosis and treatment, this does not self-correct. **Recovery:** mild, early cases can improve over weeks to months with corrected diet and vet guidance; advanced bone changes often remain even once the disease itself is controlled.

CONCRETE SIGNAL

A gecko that struggles to grip branches or climb normally needs a vet visit, not a wait-and-see approach. Climbing difficulty is often the first visible sign.

Floppy tail syndrome, impaction & tail loss

Floppy Tail Syndrome

What it is: a condition specific to crested geckos and related species where the tail droops, kinks, or hangs at an odd angle. **Cause:** often linked to enclosure setup, especially inadequate vertical and climbing space that changes how a gecko rests and grips. **Response:** review and improve the climbing structure and enclosure height (page 5); a vet visit rules out other causes if the tail doesn't improve.

Impaction

Cause: loose or oversized-particle substrate, or oversized insects. **Signs:** straining without producing waste, a visible lump along the belly, reduced appetite. **Diagnosis:** veterinary physical exam, sometimes an X-ray. **Response:** vet visit if straining or a lump persists, don't wait to see if it resolves on its own.

CONCRETE THRESHOLD

Straining without producing waste, or a firm lump along the belly, is a vet visit, not a watch-and-wait situation.

Tail Loss (Autotomy)

What it is: a crested gecko's own defense mechanism, dropping its tail when it feels grabbed or seriously threatened. **Reality check:** it is permanent. Unlike some other gecko species, a crested gecko's tail does not grow back the way it did before. It's usually not medically dangerous on its own, but it's entirely preventable: never grab or restrain by the tail (page 8), and minimize situations that startle or corner your gecko.

ALSO WORTH KNOWING

Sunken eyes paired with repeated stuck sheds often point to dehydration, check your humidity cycle first. Excess humidity with poor hygiene can lead to skin and scale issues. Persistent diarrhea or poor condition despite correct husbandry can indicate internal parasites, including cryptosporidiosis, which a vet diagnoses with a fecal exam.

Setup checklist & temperature/humidity targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Tall, vertical enclosure with secure mesh/screen ventilation
- ☐ Dense climbing structure: branches, vines, cork bark
- ☐ Live or realistic plants (pothos, philodendron, sansevieria, bromeliads)
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer
- ☐ UVB fixture (optional, low output)
- ☐ Heat bulb + dome fixture with thermostat, only if your home runs cool
- ☐ Appropriate substrate
- ☐ Shallow water dish
- ☐ CGD powder and mixing supplies
- ☐ Misting bottle, mister, or fogger for evening humidity spikes

Temperature & humidity targets

TARGET	RANGE
Cool area	70 to 75°F
Ambient	72 to 78°F
Basking area	82 to 85°F
Maximum, anywhere	85°F, never exceed
Humidity, evening peak	60 to 80%
Humidity, daytime low	40 to 50%
Photoperiod	About 12 hours

Before your gecko comes home

- ☐ Enclosure fully set up and running for a day or two first
- ☐ Cool/ambient/basking readings confirmed with a real thermometer
- ☐ Evening misting routine already producing a real humidity spike
- ☐ CGD sourced and climbing structure/plants in place before day one

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A REPTILE VET NOW IF

Any zone reads above 85°F and your gecko is lethargic · straining without producing waste, or a visible lump along the belly · a visibly limp or drooping tail with no improvement · sunken eyes with repeated stuck sheds · noticeable weight loss between log entries

READING	TARGET
Cool area	70 to 75°F
Ambient	72 to 78°F
Basking area	82 to 85°F
Maximum, anywhere	85°F, never exceed
Humidity, evening peak	60 to 80%
Humidity, daytime low	40 to 50%

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Current cool/ambient/basking readings, recent humidity pattern, weight and shed history from the Owner Log, and diet over the last two weeks.

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
Heat bulb + dome fixture (25 to 40W, only if your home runs cool)	\$20 to \$40
Thermostat	\$30 to \$35
Substrate	\$15 to \$30
Total typical setup (gecko, enclosure, UVB fixture, heating if needed, thermostat, substrate)	\$300 to \$600

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Occasional vet visits for stuck shed, impaction, or floppy tail syndrome. None of these are likely if you follow this package, but a small emergency fund still matters.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

A working thermostat on any heat source, and a real digital thermometer/hygrometer pair. This species overheats easily, above 85°F is genuinely dangerous, and you cannot manage what you don't actually measure.

Shopping list

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Gecko | ☐ Substrate |
| ☐ Tall, vertical enclosure | ☐ CGD powder + mixing supplies |
| ☐ UVB fixture (optional) | ☐ Misting bottle, mister, or fogger |
| ☐ Heat bulb + dome + thermostat, only if needed | ☐ Climbing branches, vines, cork bark |
| ☐ Digital thermometer + hygrometer | ☐ Live or realistic plants |

First 30 days & days 31 to 90

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm cool/ambient/basking readings and the humidity swing with real instruments, not by feel
- ☐ Leave your gecko alone beyond feeding and cleaning; acclimation takes about 2 weeks
- ☐ Schedule a wellness vet visit within the first few weeks

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Continue hands-off beyond feeding while acclimation finishes
- ☐ Establish a consistent evening misting routine and confirm it actually spikes and dries down
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 19

Week 4

- ☐ If your gecko meets the size, weight, and age guidance on page 8, begin very short handling sessions
- ☐ Review weight and shed pattern from the Owner Log
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 20

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Build handling sessions gradually toward the 15 minute target, staying under the 20 minute daily cap
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any drift in weight, appetite, or shed frequency
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment occasionally, not with full overhauls, per page 20

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Repeated stuck shed, toes/eyes	Humidity too low, or no evening spike	Raise humidity cycle (page 11)
Sunken eyes	Dehydration	Check humidity/misting routine
Any zone above 85°F + lethargy	Overheating	Vet now (page 14)
Limp or drooping tail	Possible floppy tail syndrome	Review climbing space, vet if no improvement (page 12)
Straining, no waste, or visible lump	Possible impaction	Vet promptly (page 12)
Tail dropped	Autotomy, a stress/defense response	Not usually an emergency; review handling (page 8)
Soft/swollen jaw, climbing difficulty	Possible MBD	Vet promptly (page 11)
Persistent diarrhea, poor condition	Possible parasites	Vet visit, fecal exam
Noticeable weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 19)
Reduced appetite, one or two meals	Often normal, especially near a shed	Monitor, recheck in a few days

Daily, weekly, monthly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Evening misting to spike humidity
- ☐ Quick visual check: eyes, tail, posture, appetite
- ☐ Confirm cool/ambient/basking readings
- ☐ Offer or refresh CGD per label schedule

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh and log in the Owner Log
- ☐ Check thermometer/hygrometer batteries and calibration
- ☐ Spot-clean substrate and wipe enclosure surfaces
- ☐ Confirm the daytime dry-down is actually happening, not just the evening spike

Monthly

- ☐ Full substrate change and deeper enclosure clean
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings
- ☐ Occasional, partial enrichment rotation, never a full overhaul

Seasonal

- ☐ Reassess room temperature and humidity swings between seasons, especially with heating/AC changes
- ☐ Recheck whether any zone risks creeping above 85°F during warm months

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	HUMIDITY %	SHED STATUS	APPETITE	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A steady weight trend and a predictable shed cycle are your best early warning system. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a change in one of those before anything else is visible.

Equipment log

ITEM	CHECKED/INSTALLED	NEXT CHECK
Misting schedule / humidifier		
Thermometer/hygrometer batteries		
UVB bulb (if used)		

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ Dense climbing structure at varied heights, securely anchored
- ☐ Live or realistic plants (pothos, philodendron, sansevieria, bromeliads)
- ☐ CGD dish placed within the climbing structure, not only on the floor

Monthly review

- ☐ Reposition or refresh one item occasionally, not a full overhaul
- ☐ Confirm the climbing structure still fits your gecko's current size
- ☐ Vary the CGD dish location to encourage natural foraging movement

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Autotomy	The voluntary dropping of a tail as a stress or defense response; permanent in crested geckos, the tail does not regrow the same way.
CGD	Crested Gecko Diet, a commercial powdered diet mixed with water that serves as this species' staple food.
Cryptosporidiosis	An internal parasitic infection, diagnosed with a veterinary fecal exam.
Dysecdysis	Incomplete or "stuck" shedding, most often affecting the toes and eyes in this species.
Floppy Tail Syndrome	A condition in crested geckos and related species where the tail droops or kinks, often linked to inadequate climbing or vertical space.
Impaction	A gastrointestinal blockage, often from loose substrate or oversized insects.
MBD	Metabolic Bone Disease: weakened bones from inadequate calcium or vitamin D3.
Photoperiod	The daily cycle of light and dark hours an enclosure is set to.
UVI	UV Index: the measurement scale used to describe basking-spot UVB intensity.

Compiled from veterinary and herpetological sources, cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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